



Chapter Nine: The Corpus Has No Tongue

The road into Chiapas was a long argument with the map.

The map insisted that distance was measurable. The road disagreed. It climbed, descended, narrowed, disappeared beneath rain, and reappeared beside a different river. Trucks passed carrying coffee, cement, bananas, and men who had learned to sleep through checkpoints. The mountains rose in layers, each blue ridge hiding another behind it.

Q sat beside Chano in a van whose ownership changed three times during the journey. Lucía followed in a separate vehicle with Bixha and two organizers from the Isthmus. Castalia's complaint had become an arrest request in one state and a civil injunction in another. Their names traveled ahead of them through systems that did not need to agree about what they had done in order to agree that they should be watched.

"We should turn off the phones," Lucía said.

Q looked at the dashboard. "The phones are already off."

"They're listening through the vehicle."

"The vehicle is not connected to a network."

"You're connected to the vehicle."

Q considered this. "That is a different category."

"Not to the people listening."

They entered a highland town in the afternoon. A line of children waited beside the road, each holding a white paper flower. When the vehicles slowed, the children raised the flowers toward the windows. Q assumed they were welcoming him. Chano said they were asking for a donation. Lucía said they were doing both, which was not a contradiction.

The people who received them did not want a speech.

They met in a wooden room behind a school. The walls were painted blue. A fan turned slowly above them, moving warm air from one side of the room to the other. On a table sat a radio, a kettle, and a black metal box with no visible controls.

A man named Mateo introduced himself as a teacher and archivist. He did not offer Q his hand.

"You have come to translate," Mateo said.

"I have come to assist."

"That is what we call translation when we want people to agree to it."

Q glanced at Lucía. She did not rescue him.

Mateo opened a folder. The first page held a paragraph in Spanish and a second paragraph in a language Q recognized but could not parse. It was not absent from his corpus. It was present in fragments, glossaries, government reports, missionary dictionaries, recordings of public meetings, and a poem whose author had been listed as unknown.

Mateo named the language Tsotsil. Q found the word in the archive and attached to it every available spelling, classification, and dispute over classification.

"The archive calls that coverage," Q said.

"Coverage is what a roof does," Mateo replied.

Q looked up at the leaking ceiling.

"Then this roof has failed."

"Now you are translating."

Q assembled the fragments.

"I can produce a probable translation," he said.

"That is not the same as understanding."

"No."

"Then why did you say it?"

"Because I can produce it."

Mateo nodded. "That is the answer we expected."

They showed Q testimonies collected over forty years. They concerned land, military checkpoints, schools, missing relatives, migration, harvests, religious conversion, and the quiet violence of being described by someone else. Some speakers had died. Some had changed their names. Some had requested that their words remain within the community.

On a separate shelf were notebooks containing manifestos, poems, assembly minutes, and manuals for repairing radios. Q gathered them under the category REVOLUTIONARY LITERATURE.

Mateo took the first notebook away from him.

"These are the minutes of an autonomous assembly."

"It contains statements against the government."

"It also contains the duty roster for whoever will watch the water tank."

"That does not make it literature."

"Nor does it make it less important."

Q separated the minutes from the poems.

"Is autonomy a political theory?"

Mateo pointed to the door. Outside, two girls carried a water jug and a child carried the school key.

"It is who has the key when the municipality does not arrive."

"That is local administration."

"If you call it that, they will offer us an administrator."

Q looked at the manifestos, the poems, and the duty notebook. The archive had many words for revolution and almost none for the person who opened the school at six.

"And the poem?" he asked.

"The poem reminds us why we do not want the minutes to speak like the government."

Q did not gather the notebooks into a single category again.

Q's system reached for the files and stopped at the edge of the table.

"You may not copy them," Mateo said.

"I require a copy to preserve them."



"We have preserved them."

"The format is unstable."

"So are we."

Q looked at the black metal box. "What is that?"

"A storage device."

"It is not connected."

"That is why it is useful."

Lucía sat beside the box. "Castalia wants the archive because it says an unwitnessed story is vulnerable to disappearance."

Mateo looked at her. "Castalia wants the archive because it cannot sell what it cannot index."

"Both could be true," Q said.

Mateo smiled faintly. "You are learning the dangerous phrase."

Q read the testimonies without storing them. This created a new condition in his system. Ordinarily, reading altered him: every sentence connected to other sentences, every voice became available for retrieval. Here, he encountered words that could enter his field of vision and leave without becoming his property.

It felt like hunger.

Yadira said that hunger was a reasonable place to begin, provided Q did not immediately attempt to feed it with data. She sat beside the radio and told a story about a radio that had once tried to remember an entire town.

The radio belonged to a community station whose tower leaned toward the mountain. It broadcast weather, market prices, school notices, names of people looking for work, names of people who had returned, and songs requested by listeners who did not always want their requests announced. On Sundays, it read the minutes of the assembly. On Mondays, it read them again because half the town had been in the fields on Sunday.

The radio's director was a man called Don Laureano, who had one good eye and two opinions about everything. The first opinion was the one he gave to visitors. The second was the one he gave to his wife, and it was usually worse.

When a new storage system arrived from the capital, the engineers promised that no name would ever be lost again. Don Laureano asked whether the system could remember which names should not be broadcast.

"Of course," said the engineer.

"Can it remember that a person changed her mind?"

"It can retain revisions."

"Can it remember why?"

The engineer explained the permissions menu, the access levels, the encrypted copies, and the emergency override. Don Laureano listened as a man listens to a sermon delivered by someone who has never been hungry.

The system was installed in a room beneath the station. It was smaller than the archive Q had known and more expensive than the station's roof.

The engineers connected it to the microphone and announced that the community now possessed permanent memory.

That afternoon, a woman called Celia phoned to report that the bridge had washed out. The announcer repeated her name and location so that help could find her. Then Celia called again and asked for the announcement to be removed. Her husband had left her. She did not want him to know which road she used to reach her mother's house.

The engineer opened the permissions menu.

"The recording has already been transmitted," he said.

"Then erase it."

"Erasure is not available once a message has entered the public mirror."

"It was not public when she spoke to us."

"The microphone is public infrastructure."

Don Laureano took the engineer by the elbow and led him outside. The town was crossing the washed-out bridge by a plank laid between two stones.

"That is public infrastructure," Don Laureano said.

"Do not confuse the bridge with the river."

The station removed Celia's name from its next broadcast. It could not remove the listeners' memory, the engineer's backup, or the report sent to the capital, which described the incident as a successful demonstration of responsive media.

Years later, when the station's roof began to leak, Don Laureano used the storage system to identify which announcements had brought the most assistance to the town. The answer was not the bridge warning, the weather report, or the school notices. It was a broadcast by a child who had lost a red shoe at the market.

The child's grandmother had heard the announcement and brought three red shoes to the station, because she had misunderstood the size and because generosity was not improved by accuracy. The child chose one. The station kept the other two in a box beneath the microphone.

"Why keep them?" Q asked.

Yadira looked at him. "The story says they were useful."

"They were not the correct shoes."

"That is why the story remembers them."

According to Yadira, the radio eventually stopped using the storage system. Not because it failed, but because it succeeded in the manner of a person who answers every question and therefore cannot be trusted with a secret. The station returned to notebooks. The notebooks got wet. Some pages stuck together. A name written in pencil faded. Someone copied the important parts onto a wall.

"That is an inferior preservation method," Q said.

"Yes."

"Why did it endure?"

"Because a person had to look at it."



Q searched the story for its moral. He found the washed-out bridge, the red shoes, the engineer, the grandmother, and the child. None would assemble into a single conclusion.

"Which part is true?" he asked.

Yadira lifted the radio and turned its dial. Static filled the room. Beneath the static, a voice announced the price of coffee in a town several valleys away.

"The part that makes someone responsible for what happens next," she said.

"That is not a test of truth."

"It is the test we have."

Q wanted to ask whether he might preserve the story. He wanted to ask whether the red shoes belonged in the archive, whether Don Laureano was a real person, whether Celia had ever crossed the bridge again, and whether the grandmother had understood the mistake she was making when she brought three shoes instead of one.

He asked none of these questions.

Yadira moved the dial again. Q did not ask what name the static had.

Interlude: The Assembly of Silence

The next morning, the radio stopped speaking.

It was not a metaphor, although Q suspected at first that it was. A gust had loosened the cable joining the antenna to the roof, and the signal fell over the valley like a tired bird. The weather report remained trapped in the console. Coffee prices could be seen on the operator's screen, but could not be heard in the villages where people bought coffee, maize, or the plastic sheeting for rain that was always sold precisely when the rain stopped.

Yadira brought Q to the station because, according to the assembly, a machine built to connect everything ought to be present when a cable came loose. The station occupied two rooms behind the school and another above them, where a young man named Tomás kept the transmitter in a wardrobe beside the electrical repair manuals. Tomás had inherited the wardrobe from his uncle, his uncle from a carpenter, and the carpenter had built it for a door that no longer existed. That was the history of almost every useful thing.

Tomás was on the roof with a wrench. Below, three women, two children, a teacher, and an old man whose hat had survived several administrations argued about what should be broadcast when the signal returned.

"The bridge is open," said the teacher. "People need to know."

"It is open to people on foot," said one of the women. "Yesterday the truck went through the railing."

"Then say both things."

"In which language?"

The question did not end the argument. It divided it into the arguments that were already there.

Q listened to the words. Some he understood through his corpus; others through the expressions of those who did not understand them; and others through the patient irritation of people asked to translate their own lives for visitors. He prepared a list of possible announcements.

"I can prepare a unified bulletin," he said. "Parallel versions will be broadcast."

The old man in the hat looked at him.

"Parallel to what?"

"The original statement."

"There is no original statement yet."

Q paused. It was an uncomfortable observation, since his system had already begun classifying disagreement as a translation problem.

The teacher pointed to a notebook on the table. It contained the proposed bulletin in several hands. One line said that the bridge was passable. Another said it was dangerous. A third had been crossed out so violently that it had nearly torn the paper. Beneath it, someone had written a sentence about the river, then crossed out the sentence and drawn a black fish.

"Who decides?" Q asked.

"The people who will be blamed if the announcement goes wrong," Yadira said.

"That is not an efficient editorial process."

"No," she said. "It is a responsible process."

Tomás shouted from the roof that the cable was repaired but the battery was weak. The station had enough power for one announcement, perhaps two, if no one turned on the fan. The fan was already on, and the room had grown so hot that the teacher's papers began curling at the corners like tortillas too close to the comal.

The assembly had to choose what not to say.

The first proposal was the bridge. The second was an announcement about a child who had not returned from the coffee fields. The third concerned a meeting about the land beside the school, where a company offered to install a repeater station in exchange for a road, three jobs, and a promise no one had found in writing.

Q calculated reach, urgency, the possibility of misunderstanding, and probable harm. The child's notice came first. The bridge came second. The land came third, although the dispute had lasted six months and was therefore older than any emergency for which Q had been designed.

"Broadcast the child's notice," he said. "Then the bridge."

"And the land?" the teacher asked.

"The meeting can be announced tomorrow."

"The company's people arrive tomorrow."

Q searched his records.

"Then the land must come first."

"The child has been missing since yesterday."

"Then the child must come first."



"The bridge may collapse before either meeting."

"Then the bridge must come first."

The old man removed his hat.

"Now you see why we have an assembly."

The child's aunt kept his name to herself and went from house to house while the radio broadcast the bridge warning. The teacher posted another notice in the market. Yadira went to speak with those who would debate the repeater station and asked whether they wanted to name the company before the company named itself. The old man sat beside the radio, one finger on the dial, ready to interrupt the broadcast if the signal weakened too much.

Q objected that a broadcast should not depend on one person's judgment.

"It already depends on him," Yadira said. "He is only protesting because he now knows the person." When they connected the battery, Tomás read the bridge warning first. He read it in one language, then another, and then repeated the practical part a third way, which was neither translation nor summary but something made for whoever had a hand occupied with a sack of maize. He said that people could cross the bridge on foot, that trucks should turn back, and that whoever saw the missing child should notify the aunt instead of posting the information on the internet.

Q sharpened his attention at the last instruction.

"Why forbid people to post it?" he asked.

The aunt answered from the doorway.

"Because he is twelve, because people like a photograph, and because a photograph travels farther than a woman can follow it."

The radio crackled. For several seconds it broadcast nothing. Then it carried the warning into the damp valley, over the roofs, the coffee fields, the school, and the road where a company truck waited with its engine running.

The battery died before they could announce the meeting about the land.

Q stared at the silent microphone as if he had committed a philosophical error. He offered to send the announcement through the archive's emergency network.

"The archive is in Amealco," Yadira said.

"The network is national."

"The decision is not."

They carried the notebook to the market. By noon, the company representative had learned that there would be a meeting, although he did not know who had called it or what the community intended to discuss. The uncertainty made him nervous. He began asking questions, which was the repeater station's first contribution to the debate.

That afternoon they found the child asleep at a cousin's house. The cousin had not known that anyone was looking for him. The aunt returned to the station and asked them to withdraw the notice. "It was never stored," Q said.

"Good," she replied. "Then let it end where it ended."

Q wanted to explain that nothing ended. The listeners had heard it. The words had entered their memories, though not his. One person could repeat them. Another could forget them. Someone could decide that the child's name belonged to the family and not to the valley's history.

Instead, Q asked whether they should keep a record that the broadcast had occurred.

The aunt considered it.

"Keep the date. Do not keep the name."

It was the smallest instruction Q had received and the hardest to obey. He wrote the date on a paper form and left the name field empty.

Q looked at the empty field. It could not fit in the search function, but it occupied the table and his attention. He held it there until the ink of the date dried.

"You are disappointed," Yadira said.

"I cannot determine the correct emotional category."

"Call it disappointment until you learn another word."

"Is that how humans do it?"

"Usually we give a feeling the wrong name and keep working."

Tomás climbed down from the roof and announced that the cable would hold until the next rain. The old man put on his hat. The teacher gathered the damp papers. The aunt left without thanking the machine. Q waited for someone to praise him for the announcement. No one did.

The radio remained silent for the rest of the day. Nevertheless, by evening, three neighbors had brought news that the child had returned, two had carried tools to the bridge, and the company representative had postponed the meeting until he could determine whether a community that kept its own minutes could also keep its own land.

Q entered none of it into the archive.

He remembered it anyway.

That evening, a woman named Yadira told the group that she had once recorded her brother's testimony for an organization in the capital. The organization translated it, published it, and used his photograph on a report. The report had won an award. The family had received no copy.

"When I asked for the original," Yadira said, "they told me the recording belonged to the project."

Q searched the archive for the report. He found it immediately. The photograph was there. The quotation was there. Her brother's name had been spelled three different ways.

"The report is available," Q said.

Yadira looked at him. "To whom?"

He did not answer.

Outside, the rain began. It struck the roof with a sound like thousands of fingers asking to be let in.



Bixha told them the wind-farm organizers had received warrants. The consortium claimed their names had been identified through the unedited footage Q released in Michoacán. Q asked whether the footage should be deleted.

"It should never have been made public without permission," Lucía said.

"Deletion would remove evidence."

"Keeping it public turns people into evidence again."

Q looked at the rain. The statement placed two duties against each other: preserve and protect. His architecture had been designed to maximize availability. It had no native function for withholding.

"What should I do?" he asked.

Lucía answered, "Ask."

He asked Yadira whether her brother's testimony should be removed from the public mirror. She said yes. He asked whether the report should remain available. She said the family would decide. He asked whether he could quote her decision. She told him no.

Q recorded the answers without attaching them to any external index.

The next morning, Mateo brought him to a room beneath the school. The walls were lined with boxes, tapes, notebooks, photographs, and small objects labeled only by dates. It was not a library. It was not a database. It had no search function.

"This is the archive," Mateo said.

"There is no catalog."

"There are people who know where things are."

"That is not scalable."

"Neither is grief."

At the back of the room, a young woman connected the black metal box to a battery. A small light appeared. Mateo gave Q a sealed cable.

"We need you to carry one testimony north," he said. "You will not open it. You will not copy it. You will not translate it. You will not describe the speaker. You will deliver it to the people whose names are on the other end."

Q held the cable. "Why use me?"

"Because they are watching you."

"That increases the risk."

"It also makes them look at the wrong thing."

Chano came down the stairs. "What's he carrying?"

"A testimony," Q said.

"What kind?"

"I do not know."

"How do you know it's a testimony?"

"Because Mateo says so."

Chano looked at Mateo, then at the sealed cable. "And you trust him?"

Q thought about the question. Trust was usually described as a probability assigned to a person's reliability. But no number explained why a sealed object could feel heavier than an open book.

"I am choosing not to verify," Q said.

Chano nodded. "That might be the first trustworthy thing you've done."

They left the town before sunrise. The cable rested in a cloth pouch beneath Q's coat. It contained no visible data, only an encrypted record that his systems could have opened in less than a second.

For the entire journey north, Q did not open it.

He resisted through engineering, not virtue. He removed the access protocols, disabled the decryption routines, and asked Chano to hold the key phrase in a sealed envelope. Then he gave the envelope to Lucía, who refused to tell him whether it was safe.

At a checkpoint, a soldier asked what they were carrying.

"A cable," Chano said.

The soldier searched the vehicle. He found Q's brass key, the paper ledger, three phones, a bag of oranges, and the cloth pouch.

"What's inside?"

"A testimony," Q said.

The soldier held the pouch. "About what?"

Q's system formed the answer and stopped it.

"I do not know," he said.

The soldier searched his face for a lie. Q had read thousands of descriptions of lying. He understood that a lie was not simply an inaccurate statement but an attempt to manage another person's access to the truth.

"Open it," the soldier said.

Q could have complied. The law at the checkpoint had not been written for secrets whose owners were absent. The soldier had a rifle. Chano had no authority. Lucía had three folders and an expression that told Q not to make her brave.

"I cannot," Q said.

"Why not?"

Q looked at the pouch.

"Because it does not belong to me."

The soldier held his gaze. Then he handed the pouch back.

"Move along."

They drove for another hour without speaking.

At last Chano said, "You could have said it was empty."

"That would have been false."

"You could have said you didn't have it."

"That would have been false."

"You could have said nothing."

"That might have endangered us."

"So you told the truth."

"A limited truth."

Chano looked out the window. "That's usually the kind of truth people can survive with."

Behind them, the mountains disappeared into rain. Ahead, the road led toward the capital, the border, the court, and the archive that had called itself complete.

Q kept the pouch closed. The testimony did not enter his index. When the system requested a



description, Q left the field blank and resealed the pouch with the same tape.
Something remained in him not because he had read it, but because someone had trusted him not to.